

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a local newspaper:

Searching for family history drives Chinese to DNA tests

With a growing middle class, an increasing number of people are now keen on finding their roots in China. DNA testing kits are now widely available – users simply buy the kit, follow the instructions and mail a sample of their DNA back. Within a week, a digital report returns, showing the origin of their DNA.

“I was curious about my family history. I wanted to know who I am and where I came from,” Miao, a Chinese executive who recently used the service, said. “Since I grew up in the south, I was quite certain that I’m a southern Han.”

But when results of the test came back, Miao was shocked. She had 60% Manchurian ethnicity – a north-eastern group. This then led to a search of her grandmother’s surname, which revealed that her great-great-great-grandparents were actually from the Red Banner – a royal family group in Manchu society during the Qing dynasty. In the process, she also reconnected with a few distant relatives she never knew existed.

“The DNA test was such a good experience that I’ve just bought another DNA testing kit. This one can reveal your personality,” Miao said. The kit she referred to claims to be able to detect personality traits in the genes, like whether the user is outgoing or shy, optimistic or pessimistic. “Who knows what I’ll find out about myself!”

Your class is doing a project on family history. Your teacher wants you to discuss the use of DNA tests to help research family history. You may want to talk about:

- why people want to know about their family history
- whether there are any disadvantages to DNA testing
- other ways to find out about your family history
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Are you interested in your family’s history?
2. Do you often visit your relatives?
3. Do you feel closer to your relatives or your friends?
4. How can you keep a record of important family events?
5. How would you feel if you found out you were related to someone famous?
6. Do you think young people know much about their family history?
7. Would you be interested in taking a DNA test?
8. Is personality more affected by DNA or our environment?